

David Emukpere

Paris, France

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PROFILE

Research engineer specializing in reinforcement learning and imitation learning for robotic manipulation, with academic and industry research experience. Focused on scalable methods for flexible physical intelligence, multimodal policy learning, and sim-to-real deployment.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Research: Reinforcement Learning, Imitation Learning, Robot Learning, Robotics

ML: PyTorch, JAX, NumPy

Robotics: ManiSkill, Isaac Sim, Panda, Piper, Sim-to-Real Deployment

Software: Python, C/C++, JavaScript, Git, Bash

EXPERIENCE

Research Scientist

05/2022 – 04/2026

NAVER LABS Europe Grenoble, France

- Designed self-supervised RL methods for safe robotic manipulation, achieving 50–60%+ improvement over prior methods.
- Developed visual RL approaches for multi-object manipulation that improved sample efficiency and deployment-time generalization; deployed policies in sim-to-real settings.
- Led simulation benchmarking and evaluation of vision-language-action (VLA) policies to analyze generalization behavior.
- Supervised research on RL fine-tuning of multimodal generative policies, improving multimodality retention and downstream task performance.
- Led publications and presented work at ICRA and IROS; contributed to research direction on policy generalization and robustness.

Research Engineer

11/2021 – 03/2022

Inria Lille-Nord-Europe Lille, France

- Benchmarked model-free RL algorithms and developed open-source tutorials for agricultural decision-making tasks in a crop management RL environment (gym-DSSAT).

Research Intern

02/2021 – 08/2021

Inria Grenoble-Rhône-Alpes Grenoble, France

- Developed a transfer learning approach combining episodic control and successor features for rapid skill acquisition and adaptation.

Software Developer

02/2018 – 06/2021

Avira Operations GmbH Germany

- Developed production features for the web dashboard and browser extension of Avira Password Manager.

PUBLICATIONS

Alberta Longhini, **David Emukpere**, Jean-Michel Renders, Seungsu Kim.

Behavioral Mode Discovery for Fine-tuning Multimodal Generative Policies. ICML 2026.

David Emukpere, Romain Deffayet, Jean-Michel Renders.

Robust Skills, Brittle Grounding: Diagnosing Restricted Generalization in Vision-Language Action Policies via Multi-Object Picking. arXiv 2026.

David Emukpere, Romain Deffayet, Bingbing Wu, Romain Brégier, Michael Niemaz, Jean-Luc Meunier, Denys Proux, Jean-Michel Renders, Seungsu Kim.

Disentangled Object-Centric Image Representation for Robotics. IROS 2025.

David Emukpere, Bingbing Wu, Julien Perez, Jean-Michel Renders.

SLIM: Skill Learning with Multiple Critics. ICRA 2024.

Romain Gautron, Emilio J. Padrón, Philippe Preux, Julien Bigot, Odalric-Ambrym Maillard,

David Emukpere.

gym-DSSAT: a crop model turned into a Reinforcement Learning environment. arXiv 2022.

David Emukpere, Xavier Alameda-Pineda, Chris Reinke.

Successor Feature Neural Episodic Control. NeurIPS Meta-Learning Workshop, 2021.

EDUCATION

M.Sc. Computer Science (Machine Learning & Robotics)

09/2019 – 08/2021

Université Grenoble Alpes & ENSIMAG Grenoble INP

GPA: 16.06 / 20

LANGUAGES

English (Fluent) | Yorùbá (Fluent) | French (Advanced) | German (Basic)

PERSONAL INTERESTS

Endurance running (5Ks to marathons), piano, jazz, football, cognitive science, reading.